

National 5 Music Literacy Analysis

2014-2025

Summary

Measure	Result
Papers analysed	11
Total questions	66
Audio required questions	31 (47%)
Audio not required questions	35 (53%)

- **Missing-note** completion is the only universal task: 11 appearances in 11 papers.
- **Key identification** appears in 8 papers; time-signature insertion and tempo marking each appear in 7.
- **F major** is the most common underlying key (4 papers); 4/4 dominates the extracts (9 papers).

Question Frequency

Question type	Occurrences	% of papers
Missing notes	11	100.0%
Key identification	8	72.7%
Time signature	7	63.6%
Tempo marking	7	63.6%
Cadence identification	6	54.5%
Pitch identification	6	54.5%
Interval identification	5	45.5%
Rhythm correction	4	36.4%
Dynamics	3	27.3%
Repeat sign	3	27.3%
Score annotation	2	18.2%
Chord identification	2	18.2%
First-time bar	1	9.1%
Note-value identification	1	9.1%

Answer Frequency

Keys and metre

Underlying key	Papers	Share
F major	4	36.4%
G major	3	27.3%
C major	3	27.3%
A minor	1	9.1%

Time signature	Papers	Share
4/4	9	81.8%
3/4	2	18.2%

Cadences, intervals and named pitches

Area	Observed correct answers
Cadences	Imperfect: 5; Perfect: 1
Intervals	Tone/2nd: 2; Semitone/2nd: 2; Octave: 1
Named pitches	B-flat: 2; F-sharp: 1; B: 1; D: 1; E: 1
Chord names	F major: 1; A minor: 1

Tempo, dynamics and repeat signs

- **Tempo placement** occurs 7 times. Andante and moderato dominate the expected or accepted responses; adagio appears in 2017.
- **Dynamics** appear 3 times: **p** in 2014, **f/mf** in 2022, and **mp** with softer alternatives in 2024.
- An **end-repeat sign** is required in 2014, 2023 and 2025. A **first-time bar** appears once, in 2021.

Higher Music Literacy Analysis

2015-2025

Summary

Measure	Result
Papers analysed	10
Total questions	60
Audio required questions	24 (40%)
Audio not required questions	36 (60%)

- **Transposition into bass clef** is the only task appearing in every paper.
- **Missing-note completion** and chord identification each appear in 9 of 10 papers.
- **Intervals** appear in every paper when identification and construction are combined.
- **F major** underpins half of the extracts; 4/4 appears in 8 of 10 papers.

Question Frequency

Question type	Occurrences	% of papers
Transposition	10	100%
Missing notes	9	90%
Chord identification	9	90%
Interval identification	7	70%
Barline insertion	4	40%
Rhythm correction	4	40%
Time signature	3	30%
Interval construction	3	30%
Scale-degree identification	3	30%
Note-value calculation	2	20%
Rest insertion	2	20%
Accidental insertion	1	10%
Key identification	1	10%

Ornament identification	1	10%
Da capo notation	1	10%

Answer Frequency

Keys, metre and clefs

Underlying key	Papers	Share
F major	5	50%
G major	3	30%
C major	1	10%
G major changing to C major	1	10%

Time signature	Papers	Share
4/4	8	80%
6/8	1	10%
12/8	1	10%

Intervals and chords

Area	Correct-answer frequency
Identified intervals	4th: 3; 5th: 3; 6th: 1
Constructed intervals	3rd: 1; 4th: 1; 5th: 1
Chord V	8 of 18 chord answers
Chord VI	4 of 18 chord answers
Chord I	3 of 18 chord answers
Chord IV	3 of 18 chord answers

Rhythmic and structural notation

- **Barline insertion** appears 4 times; complete accuracy across all missing bar lines is required for the mark.
- **Rhythm correction** appears 4 times and includes dotted rhythms, quavers and triplets.
- **Rest insertion** appears in 2019 and 2023. Da capo notation appears once, in 2024.

- **Time-signature insertion** appears only 3 times, but includes 4/4, 6/8 and 12/8.

Advanced Higher Music Literacy Analysis

2016-2025

Summary

Advanced Higher does not contain one fixed literacy question. Explicit notation tasks are distributed across several questions and musical extracts. Across 9 papers, 63 separately marked literacy questions are identified.

Measure	Result
Papers analysed	9
Total questions	63
Audio required questions	29 (46%)
Audio not required questions	34 (54%)

- Some form of **missing pitch/rhythm notation** appears in every paper.
- **Enharmonic rewriting** appears in 8 of 9 papers, making it the most stable named operation.
- **Bass-line construction** appears in 5 papers and links harmony knowledge directly to notation.
- Advanced Higher emphasises producing notation far more than naming concepts from notation.

Question Frequency

Question type	Occurrences	% of papers
Missing notes	9	100.0%
Enharmonic rewriting	8	88.9%
Bass-line construction	5	55.6%
Interval identification	4	44.4%
Accidental insertion	4	44.4%
Time signature	3	33.3%
Key identification	3	33.3%
Rest insertion	3	33.3%
Clef rewriting	3	33.3%
Rhythm completion	2	22.2%

Tie insertion	2	22.2%
Score annotation	2	22.2%
Octave rewriting	2	22.2%
Chord identification	2	22.2%
Barline insertion	2	22.2%
Repeat signs	2	22.2%
Notes and rests	1	11.1%
Note-value calculation	1	11.1%
Octave/clef rewriting	1	11.1%
Score-symbol insertion	1	11.1%
Interval construction	1	11.1%
Transposition	1	11.1%
Scale-degree identification	1	11.1%

Answer Frequency

Enharmonics, accidentals and pitch rewriting

- **Enharmonic rewriting** occurs 8 times across 8 different papers. Recorded answers include B-flat, G-flat, A-sharp and D-flat, alongside visually notated equivalents in other years.
- Separate **accidental-insertion** tasks occur 4 times, concentrated from 2019 onwards. The later answers include a natural sign in 2023 and D-sharp in the 2024 E-minor passage.
- **Clef or octave rewriting** appears in several forms: same-pitch rewriting, one octave lower, one octave higher and explicit transposition into treble clef.

Rhythm, rests and structural notation

Area	Occurrences
Rhythmic notation skill instances	15
Rest insertion	3
Tie insertion	2
Barline insertion	2
Repeat-sign insertion	2
Time-signature writing	3
Score-symbol/annotation tasks	3

Harmony and key-related notation

- **Bass-line construction** occurs 5 times and normally supplies both rhythm and chord information; the pupil converts harmonic information into correctly pitched notation.
- Explicit **key** naming appears 3 times. Confirmed named answers include B-flat major in 2016 and E minor in 2024.
- **Chord identification** appears twice in the strict notation dataset. Many other harmony concepts occur elsewhere in the listening paper but are excluded unless the score is necessary for the response.